

簡
素

KAN · SO

A WORD

Kanso

One of the seven principles behind Japanese Zen aesthetics, usually rendered as *simplicity* — but the translation hides the point. *Kanso* is not the absence of things. It is the elimination of the inessential so that the essential can finally be seen. A room can be sparse and still fail *kanso*, if what remains is the wrong thing. It can hold a dozen objects and pass, if each is necessary and nothing competes.

This is the line that separates Japandi from the cold minimalism it is so often mistaken for. Minimalism asks *how little*. Kanso asks

"Subtract until removing one more thing would take meaning away. Stop there."

